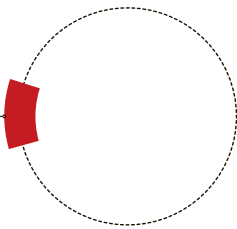


Data show Holyoke has the **lowest average** of students who meet expectations across all subject areas in grades 3 through 8 in the MCAS. In that cohort, only about **9 percent** of students meet that threshold in each subject in Holyoke Public Schools, according to the most recent statistics.



Lowest test scores just part of problem for Holyoke schools



PHOTOS BY CRAIG F. WALKER/GLOBE STAFF

Above, Kyla and Joseph Lemelin worked on getting their children Noah, 3, and Julia, 5, out the door in the morning. Snow just makes it a little more hectic. Lucas, 8, worked on his Christmas list before getting ready for school.



In struggling city, resources are lacking, students often absent, many teachers quit

By Danny McDonald
GLOBE STAFF

HOLYOKE — It's before dawn and the Lemelins' home is filled with the sounds of ebullient chaos: four children, all under the age of 12, preparing for their school day. Mason, a sixth-grader, initially puts his shirt on backward. His 8-year-old brother, Lucas, is drafting his Christmas wish list. Julia, who is in kindergarten, can't find her socks. Noah, 3, announces he can go to the bathroom on his own. It's a familiar scene across Massachusetts, as families send their kids to public schools ranked better than those in all other states. But this school district 90 miles west of Boston is different: In what one federal assessment released this year considered the top state in the nation for public education, Holyoke has, by one metric, the worst standardized test scores in Massachusetts for elementary and middle school-age students. Parents, teachers, and school officials said the problems here are widespread: Some children do not read at

HOLYOKE, Page A10

US seizes oil tanker off coast of Venezuela

Trump cites 'good reason' while others call it piracy

By Tyler Pager, Eric Schmitt, and Nicholas Nehamas
NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — The United States seized an oil tanker off the coast of Venezuela on Wednesday, a dramatic escalation in President Trump's pressure campaign against Nicolás Maduro, the leader of Venezuela. Speaking at the White House before an event on a new luxury visa program, Trump announced the operation and said it was "a large tanker, very large," adding, without elaboration, that "other things are happening." When asked about the ship's oil, Trump said, "Well, we keep it, I guess." He declined to say who owned the tanker. "It was seized for a very good reason," he added. Three US officials, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe a law enforcement operation, said the ship was carrying Venezuelan oil. They said there was no resistance from the crew and no casualties. In a statement, Venezuela's government called the seizure a "barefaced robbery and an act of in-

VENEZUELA, Page A7

Children's plans mental health hospital for kids Hales make their biggest donation — \$100 million

By Jessica Bartlett
GLOBE STAFF

Boston Children's Hospital will build a new \$640 million pediatric psychiatric hospital in Brighton, officials announced Wednesday, funded with the largest donation in the hospital's history. The \$100 million gift from Quincy billionaire philanthropists Rob and Karen Hale is the largest donation the couple has made to a single entity. The project has the potential to be transformative for the region's capacity to offer mental health care, as demand for such services has soared in the aftermath of the pandemic. "We're going to change the landscape in the country for childhood psychiatric health, and Children's is bringing in all the right people, has the vision, has the plans," Karen Hale told the Globe. "And for us to be able to be a part of that and support it, there's nothing else that I think we do that is more important." The 116-bed building, to be located on the

CHILDREN'S, Page A10

Torment and Trial | Chapter Five

A jury had to decide Latarsha Sanders' fate. The full story was kept from them.

By Yvonne Abraham | Globe Columnist

The Trial ■ "The easy thing to do will be to say you have to be crazy to kill your own kids, to stab them so many times parts of their bodies are unrecognizable," prosecutor Amanda Fowle told jurors in her opening argument. "The facts will show you that it's not a question of, was she crazy? It's a question of how evil was she on that weekend — how bad and evil and selfish of a mother was she?" From the beginning, it was clear the prosecution's strategy was to deny Latarsha Sanders' mental illness and demolish her character. By the time her trial began at the Superior Court in Plymouth in late December 2022, everyone agreed that Sanders had killed her sons Marlon, 8, and La'son, 5, almost five years earlier. So the only matter jurors had to decide at her trial was this one: Was Sanders criminally responsible for the gruesome killings, and therefore guilty of murder in the first degree? Or had she been so impaired by mental illness that she could not control her actions or appreciate the wrongfulness of them?

SANDERS, Page A6



Latarsha Sanders was convicted of first-degree murder for killing her children Marlon, 8, and La'son, 5, in 2018, even though she was experiencing severe symptoms of mental illness at the time. This series explores what led up to the horrific day when Sanders killed her sons, and how the justice system treated Sanders and her family afterward.

PHOTO FROM SHALEA SANDERS; PHOTO ILLUSTRATION BY RYAN HUDDLE/GLOBE STAFF

A federal judge ordered the Trump administration to immediately end its deployment of California National Guard troops in Los Angeles, ruling that intense protests had long ended. **A2.**

The Boston City Council approved a steep increase in property taxes for homeowners, all but ending the mayor's push for an alternative. **B1.**

The Federal Reserve reduced its key interest rate by a quarter-point for the third time in a row but signaled it may hold off on more. **D4.**

Ukraine was expected to give its latest peace proposals to US negotiators, President Volodymyr Zelensky said, a day ahead of his urgent talks with leaders from 30 other countries. **A3.**



Snap to it

Thursday: Windy, colder. High 36-41. Low 21-26.
Friday: More of the same. High 33-38. Low 24-29.

Weather and Comics, D5-6.

VOL. 308, NO. 164

Suggested retail price \$4.00

